The Diamant rocket took off and the first three stages burned out beautifully. The fourth stage, which was at the core of this experiment, did not ignite. The launch was a failure. As the grand lunch waited, scientists uneasily stared at each other, thinking if they have to eat a humble pie and move to the dining table. I took Roussel to a corner and asked why the fourth stage did not ignite. It was probably a state secret of the French, but Roussel somehow decided to tell me the truth. 'Promise you won't tell anyone. It didn't ignite because now I realise that I forgot to put the igniter.' I was stunned at Roussel's honesty and a premier space agency's oversight.

Years later, in a casual conversation, U R Rao said space scientists may have several secrets and that they do not share it with the higher-ups despite review committees probing failures. And Rao mentioned the Diamond rocket disaster. He somehow knew about the stupidity of the French failure.

'Do you know why the French rocket failed,' he asked me.

I knew I was breaking my promise to Roussel, when I told Rao yes, I knew.

'You know?' Rao was surprised.

I told him that Roussel had confided in me.

'How can they do such a thing?' Rao continued.

I couldn't contain myself.

'Your boys are also forgetful, Prof Rao,' I said.

'What do you mean?'

I told him the story of Calla's preoccupation in the block house and how he forgot to switch to external power, draining the transponder battery.

MEETING INDIRA GANDHI

Not all countdowns were as casual as that of the Judi rocket that had a 'premature ejection'. To the layman, the controller who was counting 10, 9, 8, 7 … may sound to be the most important person, but in real, it is